

Reference Services in the Library

Lesson 4: Navigating the Library Catalog

Navigating the Library Catalog - Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **OPAC (Online Public Access Catalog)** – the library's searchable, web based database of all holdings.
2. **Search Strategies** – using keywords, Boolean operators, truncation, and field tags to refine results.
3. **Filters & Limits** – narrowing results by format, language, publication date, location, etc.
4. **Item Details & Availability** – interpreting bibliographic records, call numbers, and status (available, on loan, in process).
5. **Placing Holds & Requests** – how to request an item that is checked out or stored off site.

Summary

The OPAC is the gateway to a library's collection, allowing you to locate books, e books, journals, media, and special items from any computer or mobile device. Effective searching starts with choosing the right keywords and, when needed, applying Boolean operators (AND, OR, NOT) or truncation symbols (*) to capture variations of a word. After the initial search, filters let you quickly zero in on the format you need (e.g., "e book"), the language, publication year, or the specific branch where the item is shelved.

Each result shows a bibliographic record that includes the title, author, publication information, call number, and current availability. If an item is checked out, the record will indicate its due date and give you the option to place a hold. Holds queue the item for you and notify you when it's ready for pickup. Understanding how to read these records and use the catalog's tools saves time and ensures you can access the resources you need efficiently.

Important Points

- **Start Broad, Then Narrow:** Begin with a simple keyword search; add filters only after you see the initial result set.
- **Use Field Tags (if available):**
 - `ti:` for title, `au:` for author, `su:` for subject, `isbn:` for ISBN.
 - Example: `au:"Jane Austen"` finds works by Jane Austen.
- **Boolean Operators:**
 - `AND` /– must include both terms (e.g., `climate AND policy`).
 - `OR` /– either term (e.g., `adolescent OR teen`).
 - `NOT` /– exclude a term (e.g., `biology NOT genetics`).
- **Truncation & Wildcards:** Use `\*` to replace any number of characters (`educat\*` finds education, educator, educational).
- **Filters to Apply:**

- **Format:** book, e book, DVD, journal, database.
- **Location:** main branch, reserve desk, off site storage.
- **Date Range:** limit to recent years or a specific period.
 - **Check Availability Icons:**
- Green check != /available now.
- Clock != /on loan; shows due date.
- Arrow != /in process or being transferred.
 - **Placing a Hold:** Click “Place Hold” or “Request.” You’ll receive an email/notification when the item is ready.
 - **Export/Save Citations:** Most OPACs let you export records in MLA, APA, Chicago, or RIS formats for reference managers.

Examples

Example 1 – Finding a Recent E Book on Renewable Energy

1. **Search box:** `renewable energy`
2. **Filter:** Format !' **E book**; Publication date !' **2020–2024**
3. **Result:** **Renewable Energy: A Primer** (2022) – shows green check != available.
4. **Action:** Click the title != view details != select “Download PDF” or “Read Online.”

Example 2 – Locating a Classic Novel in Physical Form

1. **Search box:** `ti:"Pride and Prejudice"` (using the title field tag).
2. **Result list:** Shows several editions.
3. **Filter:** Format !' **Print book**; Location !' **Main Library – Fiction**.
4. **Record shows:** Call number **PR4034 .P7 2003**, status **On loan – due 05/12**.
5. **Action:** Click “Place Hold.” You’ll be notified when the copy returns and is ready for pickup at the Fiction desk.

Quick Review

1. What does OPAC stand for, and what is its primary purpose?
2. How would you search for all journal articles authored by “Maria Garcia” using a field tag?
3. Which Boolean operator would you use to find resources that discuss either “climate change” or “global warming”?
4. If a record shows a clock icon, what does that indicate and what should you do to access the item?
5. Name two filters you might apply when you need an e book published in the last five years.

Further Reading

- Advanced Boolean searching and nesting (using parentheses).
- Using citation tools and exporting records to reference managers.
- Interlibrary loan (ILL) processes for items not held in the local collection.
- Navigating subject headings and classification systems (Dewey Decimal vs. Library of Congress).
- Mobile library apps: searching the catalog on smartphones and tablets.

